

THE SCORPION

Scorpius



SIZE RANKING 33

BRIGHTEST STAR
Antares (α) 1.0
(variable)

ABBREVIATION Sco

GENITIVE Scorpī

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
June–JulyFULLY VISIBLE
44°N–90°S

This beautiful and easily recognizable zodiacal constellation is situated in the southern sky. It depicts a scorpion (see panel, below) whose raised tail is marked by a curve of stars extending into a rich area of the Milky Way toward the center of the Galaxy.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Antares, or Alpha (α) Scorpī (see p.256), is a red supergiant hundreds of times larger than the Sun. It fluctuates from about magnitude 0.9 to 1.2 every 4 to 5 years.

Normally, Delta (δ) Scorpī is of magnitude 2.3, but in the year 2000 it unexpectedly began to brighten by over 50 percent. Whether it will remain at its new magnitude or return to its previous value is unknown.

Beta (β) Scorpī is a line-of-sight pair with components of 3rd and 5th magnitudes, while Omega (ω) Scorpī is an even wider unrelated pair, with stars of 4th magnitude. A small telescope easily splits Nu (ν) Scorpī into a double with components of 4th and 6th magnitudes. Mu (μ) Scorpī is another naked-eye pair, with stars of 3rd and 4th magnitudes.

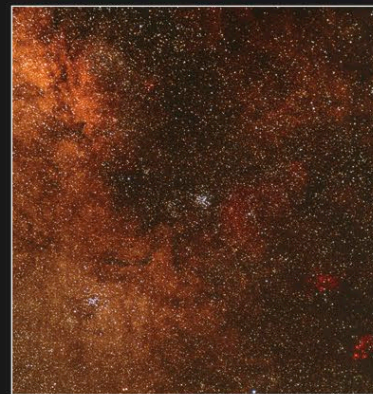
More complex is Xi (ξ) Scorpī, a white and orange pair of stars of 4th and 7th magnitudes. In the same field of view a fainter and wider pair

can also be seen. All four stars are gravitationally linked, making this a genuine quadruple.

The open cluster M7 is visible to the naked eye as a hazy patch. It has dozens of stars of 6th magnitude and fainter scattered over an area twice the apparent width of a full moon. About twice as distant is M6, which is known as the Butterfly Cluster (see p.290) because of its shape when viewed through binoculars. On one wing lies BM Scorpī, a variable orange giant. Near Antares, M4 (see p.294) is one of the closest globular clusters to us, at 7,000 light-years away.

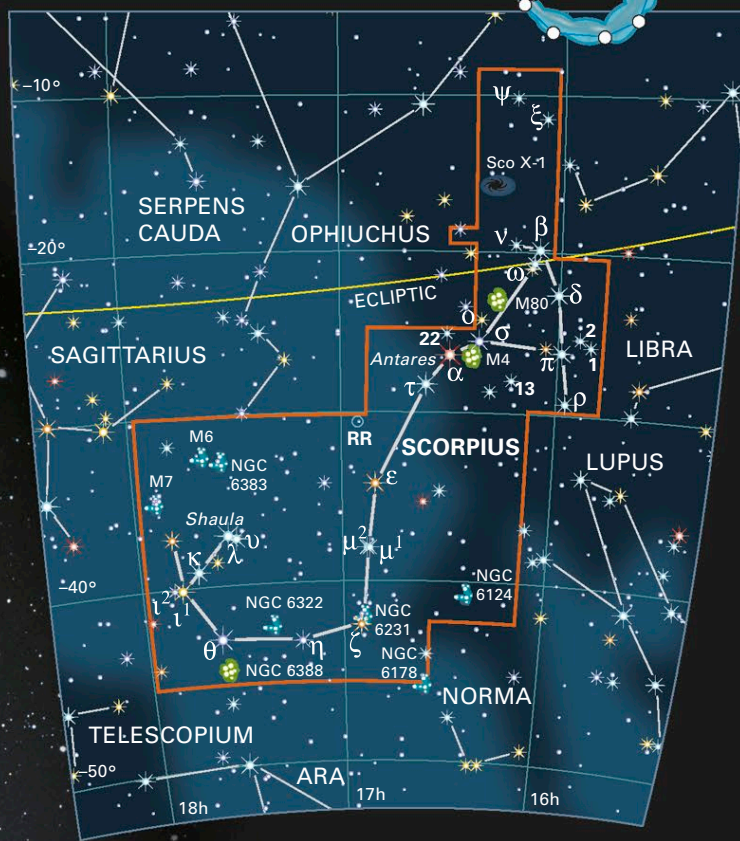
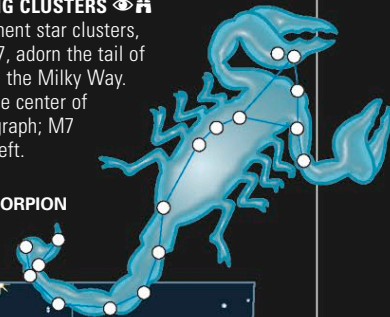
Just too far south to have featured on Charles Messier's list (see p.73) is the open cluster NGC 6231. Its brightest member, 5th-magnitude Zeta (ζ) Scorpī, has a 4th-magnitude companion much closer to us.

The strongest X-ray source in the sky is Scorpius X-1. This consists of a 13th-magnitude blue star orbited by a neutron star.

GLITTERING CLUSTERS

Two prominent star clusters, M6 and M7, adorn the tail of Scorpius in the Milky Way. M6 is at the center of this photograph; M7 is bottom left.

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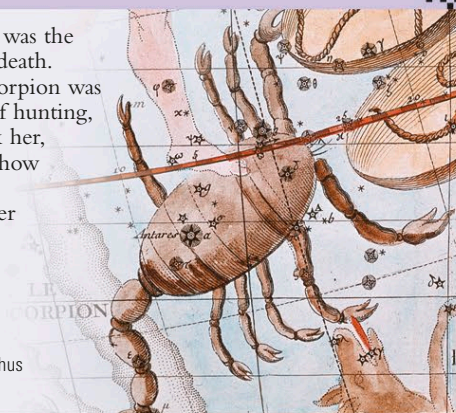
MYTHS AND STORIES

THE DEATH OF ORION

In Greek mythology, Scorpius was the scorpion that stung Orion to death. According to one story, the scorpion was sent by Artemis, the goddess of hunting, after Orion had tried to attack her, while another account relates how Mother Earth dispatched the scorpion to humble Orion after he had boasted that he could kill any wild beast.

MISPLACED FOOT

Like other old star charts, Jean Fortin's *Atlas Céleste* shows the foot of Ophiuchus awkwardly overlapping Scorpius.

STING IN THE TAIL

This view of Scorpius has south at the top and shows the scorpion raising its curving tail as though to strike. Its heart is marked by the red star Antares.